the European countries there has been efforts on the part of the government to decentralize the powers and functions, which were otherwise centralized. The question of devolution of finances, the jurisdictional issues in policing, transport and inter-state commerce are some of the pending and irritants in the case of the developed countries. Whereas in the developing countries, there is more and more attempt on the part of the central or federal governments to centralize the powers and financial resources. In India the constant pressure is being exerted on the central government for more devolution of administrative and financial powers to state as well as local governments.

12.4 Origin and development of Local Governments in India

In tracing the origin and development of local governments in India, one finds the evidences of the existence of local governments even before the times of Christ (BCE). The period between 600 BCE to C.E. 600 witnessed the rise and fall of republics. During this period, there emerged Mahavira (founder of Jainism) and Buddha (founder of Buddhism). Villages were classified according to size and mode of habitation in Jain and Buddhists literature.

The religious orders founded by Buddha and Mahavira observed highly democratic procedures in arriving at decisions. Kautilya's Arthshastra (Treatise)gives a comprehensive account of the system of village administration prevailing in his time In the days of Maurya the village and the district were units of administration.

In the South Indian peninsula, the existence of the local self governing institutions could be traced well before the period of the Christian calender. The historical period can be grouped in to early Chola period, Kalabira period, and the later Chola period, the emergence of Vijayanagara empire, entry of Muslims and Moghuls and the British. There were very little evidence available about the system of local governance in the early Chola Period(which dates back to Before Christ) and the Kalabira Period.

But there were some account of existence of local governments during the times of Pandyas (rulers of deep south India) and the Pallavas (rulers of mid South india). But Cholas (rulers who ruled Mid Tamil country) period witnessed a well developed local self governments. The inscriptions of Paranthaka Chola–I (919.ADCCE – 922ADCCE) from Utthiramerur in Kanchipuram district of Tamilnadu state, give detailed account of local self government. They inform that each village had an assembly consisting of all adult males and their involvement in general matters. These assemblies are of two types, the "Ur" and the Mahasabha". The third kind was the nagaram (town) confined to mercantile towns(trading centers) and the fourth was the "nadu". Hence two types of institutions were mentioned one nadu (village and other areas) and nagaram (urban centers).

In general there is little information on the functioning of any village assemblies prior to the 9th century. Both "nadu" and "Nagaram" were concerned about the control and regulation of land holdings, management of irrigation works,

11th Std Political Science Eng Medium Vol-2_Chapter 12.indd 226 07/12/2022 14:33:30